

SYNTAX AS IDEOLOGY: THETA ROLE ASSIGNMENT AND OPPRESSION IN ADICHIE'S *HALF OF A YELLOW SUN*

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Abstract

This paper is a syntactic investigation of how theta roles serve as a means through which meanings-oppression, ideology and agency, are encoded in Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's Half of a Yellow Sun through the framework of Theta Theory and Critical Discourse Analysis. Theta roles, a theory of Government and Binding (G.B) postulated by Noam Chomsky was used to show how structural arrangements of verbs and their arguments produce meaning. This position is crucial because literary studies have relied on transitivity and discourse-based approaches to examine agency and dialogue. This paper extends theta theory into literary analysis to depict how agency, thematic structures and ideology are linguistically encoded. Using the qualitative method, twenty-four sentences were selected and analyzed for argument, structure and role assignment. The findings of this work reveal how theta roles such as: theme, location, agent, experiencer, and goal are used in the projection of oppression and power imbalance in the text under study. This demonstrates its relevance in the decoding of implicit ideology.

Key words: Theta roles, syntax, thematic relations, theme, agent, experiencer.

INTRODUCTION

Language is a tool or a code system used by human beings for communication and exchanges. Sweet (2014) defines language as a system of conventional structures which involves spoken, manual, or written symbols by means of which human beings as members of a social group and participants in its culture employ in expressing themselves.

The definition above, once again, highlights the importance of language in any given society. Language is organized in words, clauses and sentences. Words are found in clauses, while clauses are found in sentences. Sentences in turn are formed following stipulated rules. This is where the study of syntax becomes relevant since it deals with the structuring and ordering of elements in a sentence.

Nwala (2015, p. 117) opined that 'the knowledge of the syntax of a language gives one the

linguistics competence to know which words in a sentence 'go with' or 'modify' which other words; when to use certain words and when not to'.

From the period of traditional grammar to the modern approaches of language analysis, linguists have tried to study and come up with theories to describe language, its functions and operations and one of such theories is Government and Binding (G.B) alongside its sub theories such as:

- a. θ theory (Theta)
- b. Government theory
- c. X^1 theory
- d. Binding theory
- e. Case theory
- f. Control theory
- g. Bounding theory.

These theories have each done an excellent job in describing the universal features of language, however this work focuses on 'theta theory' and its application in the analysis of sentences used in Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Half of Yellow Sun*. This is because according to Cowper (1992, p. 48) 'any description that fails to take account of thematic relations is missing a large part of how sentences are put together'. And secondly, any adequate framer of a language must give information about the relationships between syntax and semantics (Gruber 1965, Jackendoff 1972, Chomsky 1980, Ndimele 1992 and Nwala 2015). Against this background therefore, this paper looks at thematic roles the predicate assigns to Noun Phrases (NP) in various argument position in the selected sentences of Adichie's *Half of a Yellow Sun*.

The aim of this work is to examine how theta roles in sentences are used in the analysis of *Half of a Yellow Sun* to project oppression and ideology.

Previous studies on Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Half of a Yellow Sun* have focused mainly on the subject matter of the novel and its brave reflection of the Nigeria society. Different attention has equally been paid to the different types of sentences visible in the text, but little has been done on the structural arrangement of verbs and their arguments in literary works and how these align to produce meaning. This is what informed this work- the identification of a gap in the study of theta roles as it relates to the language of literary works and in this study, *Half of a Yellow Sun*.

This study is important as it reveals how thematic roles project meaning in literary texts and how theta roles serve not only as a restriction to the infiniteness of the X-bar theory but also as meaning encoders in literary texts.

Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA)

Through the prism of CDA, language is examined as a tool used in discourse to reproduce or challenge societal inequalities and power dynamics. This approach to language study doesn't only consider the functional role of language but also the use of language as a social practice (Fairclough 1995). This means that there is behaviour and implicit ideology embedded in language use in discourse situations.

CDA examines how language is deployed in social and political contexts to reflect power abuse, dominance and inequality as well as how they are structured and reproduced as resistance through text and talk (van Dijk 1993). This means that language is never dormant or neutral. Grammatical choices such as vocabulary, voice and other structures are used to project individuals and opinions into different categories such as dominance, oppression, resistance and ideology. Through language use positions of individuals are determined in discourse. A critical analysis of language can reveal the powerful, powerless, in group and out group solidarities, asymmetrical relations and hegemonic dominance in literary works, speeches and every day conversations. This makes it crucial in the analysis of the text under study *Half of a Yellow Sun*.

Theta Roles

Theta roles are selectional restrictions brought about by the infiniteness of the X-bar (X^1) theory. They describe the function and meaning of phrases in a sentence. Theta theory simply defines the functional relationship between verbs and their arguments (Nwala, 2015).

Carnie (2007, p. 222) defined theta roles as 'bundles of thematic relations that cluster on one argument'. The above simply means that different thematic information or meaning are derivable in different arguments of a sentence.

Thematic relations in a clause was first proposed in the generative framework by Jeffrey Gruber (1965) and further expanded by Jackendoff (1972) and Chomsky (1980) theta roles are similar but different from thematic relations. This is because in semantics more than one thematic relation may hold between a particular verb and a particular noun phrase (NP) but in syntax a theta role is assigned to one and only one argument.

A theta role is a set of thematic relations assigned by a particular element to a particular position (Cower 1992).

Nwala (2015, p. 170) defined argument as 'nouns or pronominals that occupy certain positions in sentences, which are assigned semantic roles by the verb'. So a verb theta (marks) its arguments.

E.g murder

This verb assigns two thematic roles

Agent	Patient
Np	Np

i) $\frac{\text{Mary}}{\text{agent}}$ Murdered $\frac{\text{her husband}}{\text{patient}}$

Clauses are equally assigned arguments. Haegeman (1994, p. 53) opined that 'clause too can thus be arguments of the predicate'.

E.g. $\frac{\text{The police}}{\text{Agent}}$ announced $\frac{\text{that the pig has been stolen}}{\text{Theme}}$

Here, the underlined clause is the 'theme'

Types of thematic relations

1). **Agent:** this is the initiator/ doer of an action. The agent must be capable of volition (desire) or deliberate action

E.g. i. $\frac{\text{Chelsea}}{\text{Agent}}$ slapped the dog.

ii $\frac{\text{Precious}}{\text{Agent}}$ hit Chelsea.

iii. A falling brick hit Lanre.

In example (i) and (ii) Chelsea and Precious are both agents because they're capable of performing the action of the verb and thereby causing a psychological effect on the object or patient. But in *iii* 'A falling brick' has no volition to hit Lanre therefore it's not an agent.

2). **Goal:** This is the entity towards which motion takes place. 'Motion' may be concrete or abstract.

E.g. i) Princewill gave the highest portion to $\frac{\text{Elizabeth}}{\text{goal}}$

ii) Uju went from Abuja to $\frac{\text{Port Harcourt}}{\text{Goal}}$

3) **Source:** This is the entity from which motion takes place. 'Motion' may be concrete or abstract.

E.g. i) Emeka travelled from $\frac{\text{England}}{\text{source}}$ to America

ii) He made his stew from $\frac{\text{weed}}{\text{source}}$

4) **Location:** The place (concrete or abstract) where something is situated.

E.g i) Lilian lives in $\frac{\text{Port Harcourt}}{\text{Location}}$

$\frac{\text{oluomachi}}{\text{Location}}$ is with the book

5) **Experiencer:** The individual who feels or perceives the event. This entity is aware of the action or state described by the predicate but is not in control of the action or the state.

E.g i) $\frac{\text{Kambili}}{\text{experiencer}}$ feared the dark

ii) $\frac{\text{Coker}}{\text{Experiencer}}$ saw the couple

6) **Recipient:** This is a subtype of the 'goal' thematic relation. It occurs in actions describing a change of possession such as 'sold', 'donate', 'give', 'receive' etc.

E.g i) John sold the bag to $\frac{\text{Frances}}{\text{recipient}}$

ii) We gave $\frac{\text{Courage}}{\text{recipient}}$ a present

$\frac{\text{Buhari}}{\text{recipient}}$ received a gift from Daura

7) **Instrument:** this is the object with which an action is performed or the means by which something comes about.

E.g i) We cut the cake with a $\frac{\text{knife}}{\text{instrument}}$

8) **Benefactive:** This is the one for whose benefit the event took place. The entity that benefits from an event

E.g. i) The Company organized a birthday party for $\frac{\text{knife}}{\text{benefactive}}$

ii) I bought these roses for $\frac{\text{Jane}}{\text{benefactive}}$

9) **Patient:** This is the entity which undergoes an action or a change in state

E.g. i) The governor fired $\frac{\text{his aide}}{\text{patient}}$

ii) The policeman shot $\frac{\text{the thief}}{\text{patient}}$

iii) The dog bit $\frac{\text{the baby}}{\text{patient}}$

10) **Percept:** an entity which is experienced or perceived

E.g i) Oge saw the $\frac{\text{monstrous being}}{\text{percept,}}$

$\frac{\text{The mermaid tales}}{\text{percept,}}$ frightened the children

11. **Theme:** The entity that is moved by the action of the verb, or the entity whose location is described

E.g i) The Lecturer gave $\frac{\text{a book}}{\text{Theme}}$ to the students.

ii) Mariah hid $\frac{\text{the bail}}{\text{Theme}}$ under the table.

iii) The woman announced $\frac{\text{that they were going on}}{\text{theme}}$ strike.

Theta Criterion

- Each argument is assigned one and only one theta role
- Each theta role is assigned to one and only one argument. (Carries 2007, cited Nwala 2015, p. 173).

Verbs assign arguments to Noun Phrases, thus if we know what a verb means, we know intuitively what thematic relations can occur with it. This information according to the generativists such as Chomsky is stored in the lexicon.

For instance, the verbs 'eat' and 'kill' would naturally take two NP's i.e., the 'agent' and the 'patient'. This is because a verb such as 'eat' would naturally inquire to know 'who ate + what was eaten' thus 'agent + patient'.

E.g $\frac{[\text{Lilian}]}{\text{Agent}}$ ate $\frac{[\text{the hamburger}]}{\text{patient}}$

In the same order

[Ebuka] killed [the rat]

Agent patient

Represented in θ grid

Eat	Agent Lilian	ate	Patient The hamburger
Kill	Agent Ebuka	killed	Patient The rat

[NP₁ Eat NP₂]

NP₁ = agent

NP₂ = patient

In the sentences above we have both external and internal arguments. External arguments are usually the subjects of a verb while internal arguments occur in the predicate position (Nwala, 2015).

It is imperative to know that while theta roles are mapped to one and only one argument as represented in the sentences above thematic roles are not a one to one mapping. Jackendoff (1972) noted that the relationship between noun phrases in a sentence and the thematic is not one to one. This means that a single noun phrase can bear more than one thematic role. For example

[Agent

[Sharon] Stole a book from the Library
Agent theme source
goal

[Michael] looked into the water port
theme goal
Agent

Syntax and Syntactic Analysis

Syntax is the study of the set of rules, principles and processes that oversees the ordering and structuring of elements in a sentence. 'Syntax deals with the specifying of how lexemes combine with one another in particular constructions (Lyons 2019, p. 102). When we talk about syntax, we talk about the grammatical structure of a text.

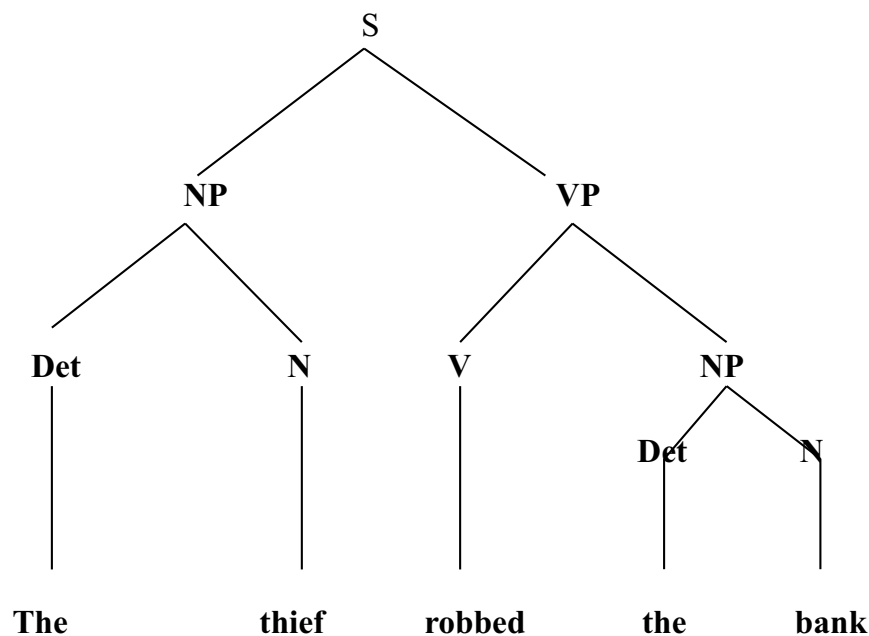
Syntactic analysis is the practice of 'determining the relevant components of a sentence and describing these parts (constituents) grammatically (Banjar, 2011). In this form of analysis, there is a breaking down of a sentence into its constituents and the labeling of each constituent stating what type of constituent it is and what grammatical function it performs. In other words, syntactic analysis is the process of analyzing a sentence structure with the rules of formal grammar.

There are different types of sentences and they are analyzed at four distinct levels, usually called linguistic taxonomy. They are:

1. The sentence level
2. The clause
3. The Phrase
4. The word

The constituents of a sentence structure can be represented using a tree diagram or brackets.

E.g. The thief robbed the bank



Another example: the python killed the dog and swallowed it.

We can analyze the sentence below using brackets

i Sentence level

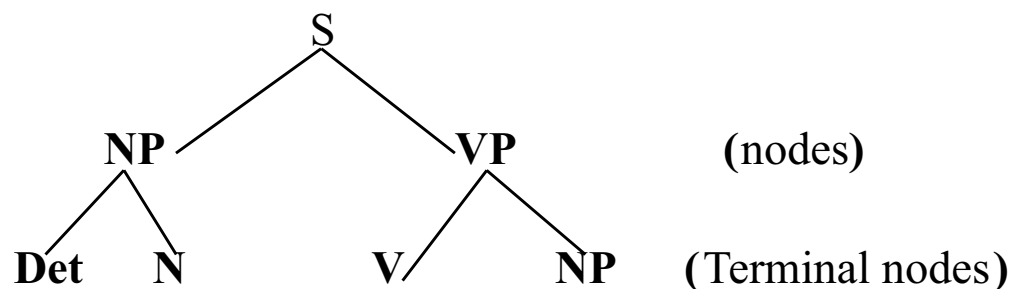
[The python killed the dog and swallowed it]- [S₁]

ii Clause level

[[The python killed the dog] and [swallowed it]]- [S₁[S₂] and [S₃]]

So the constituents of a sentence can be analyzed using the brackets as indicated above or with the help of a tree diagram. A tree diagram is a visual or graphic representation of the constituent structure of a sentence. It depicts vividly how a sentence is structured out of its constituent phrases and how each of the phrases is structured out of its component words.

e.g.



Syntactic Categories

Syntactic units are morphemes, words, phrases, clauses and sentences.

- a) The Morpheme
A morpheme is the smallest linguistic unit within a word that conveys a meaning such as 'un' in the word 'unbelief' and 'in' in the word 'invalid'. Morphemes are generally short sequences of sounds with meanings used to build words. They are an integral and essential part of sentences since they are used to show agreement and grammaticality in sentences (Anurudu, Priye & Okoye 2019).
- b) The Word is a 'minimum independent linguistic unit having an identifiable meaning and grammatical function with a fairly consistent phonological shape' (Ndimele 1999, p.3). The word is therefore the most fundamental and meaningful unit of grammar. A word is meaningful because it can stand on its own and express a thought or meaning.
- c) The phrase is a group of words that functions as a single unit. In the string of words that

make up a phrase, one is usually the head and this 'head' can replace the other words and still express a meaning. A phrase functions as a part of a larger construction. Phrases are named according to the most important (head) word in the phrase. Thus we have:

- | | |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------|
| i) The Noun Phrase (NP) | 'The man' |
| ii) Verb Phrase (VP) | 'will buy the book' |
| iii) Adjectival Phrase (AdjP) | 'very expensive ornament' |
| iv) Prepositional Phrase (PP) | 'on top of the table' |
| v) Adverbial Phrase (AdvP) | 'very beautifully made' |

d) The Clause

A clause is a group of words that contain a subject and a predicate. We have two types of clause: dependent and independent clause. An independent clause can stand on its own and express a complete thought while a dependent clause can't.

E.g. I will come if it rains.
Independent dependent

We have:

- i) Noun Clause
- ii) Adjectival Clause
- iii) Adverbial Clause

These clauses function as nouns, adjectives and adverbs. They are therefore named after their functions.

E.g. The girl who was molested is my niece.
(Adjectival clause)

That Peter travelled, surprised the manager.
(Noun clause)

He tore the woman as a leopard tears its prey.
(Adverbial clause)

e) The Sentence

A sentence is a group of words that usually contains a subject and a verb and expresses a complete thought (Anurudu, Priye & Okoye 2019, p. 120). A sentence can be made up of a single clause or a combination of clauses. This means that a sentence can have more than one subject and one verb.

Sentence types include: simple sentence, complex sentence, compound sentence and compound complex sentence.

Analyzing Theta Roles in *Half of a Yellow Sun*

1. <They> are killing <us> like ants (p. 179)

- | | agent | patient | |
|-----|---------------------------------------|--|---------------------------------------|
| 2. | <We>
agent | finished <the whole family>
patient | (p.185) |
| 3. | <Biafra>
goal | is <born>
Theme | (p. 202) |
| 4. | <The Igbo>
theme | must go | (p. 183) |
| 5. | <Our eyes>
experiencer | have seen plenty | (p. 179) |
| 6. | <Secession>
theme | is the only way | (p. 200) |
| 7. | <It>
theme | was <Allah's will>
goal | (p.185) |
| 8. | He | said <Hundreds were killed>
theme | <in Zaria alone> (p. 191)
location |
| 9. | <Richard>
experiencer | felt himself wet his trousers | (p. 190) |
| 10. | <She>
experiencer | stopped <when she saw bodies>
theme | |
| 11. | Aunty Ifeka>
experiencer | lay <on the veranda>
location | (p. 183) |
| 12. | <The cuts on her naked body>
theme | were smaller ... | (p. 183) |
| 13. | <Uncle Mbaezi>
experiencer | lay facedown in an ungainly twist, legs splayed. | (p. 184) |
| 14. | <In sabon Gari>
location | the first street was <empty> | |
| 15. | <Nnaemeka>
agent | Knelt <down>
theme | |
| 16. | <Passengers>
agents | were crouched <behind the chairs>
location | |

- | | |
|-----|--|
| 17. | <Men> got on their knees <to lower their heads to the floors> (p. 187)
theme goal |
| 18. | <The soldiers> ran out to the tarmac and into the aeroplane and pulled out Igbo people
agents |
| | <Who had already boarded and lined them up and shot them and left them lying there, their bright clothes splashes of colour on the dusty black stretch> (p. 190) |
| 19. | <Ugwu> recoiled and nearly dropped the flask. (p. 180)
experiencer |
| 20 | <Olanna> saw <the smoke> rising like tall, grey shadows before smelt the scent of burning.
experiencer |
| 21. | <The railway stations> are full of our people
location |
| 22. | <The man's right eye> was gone, in its place, a juicy red pulp (p.180)
theme |
| 23. | <Flies> buzzed everywhere
theme |
| 24. | <Richard> felt cold sweat weighing on his eyelashes. (p. 191)
experiencer |

Discussion

Theta role is the relationship between verbs and their arguments. Theta roles as used in the text help to uncover agency, the oppression and savagery meted out to the Christians from the east during the events that led to the Nigerian Biafran war. Through it we see an unmasking of salient bitter truths the writer tries to circumvent in order to appear less provocative. These argument roles help to shed light on the background and backdrop against which the novel is set. The thematic meanings help readers grasp a better understanding of the narrative including those not explicitly stated, including the oppressor, the oppressed and the motive for the violence. The theta roles identified in the data above are:

1. Theme

The theme is the entity that directly receives the action of the verb. It is what is being talked about in a sentence. Instances from the sentences above project what the novel is talking about. Themes such as:

'The cuts on her naked body'

'Hundreds were killed '

'The scent of burning'

All depict violence and oppression meted out to the patients. Power asymmetry is decoded in that one group- the agents- have the leverage to carry out such violence on another group who cannot retaliate. This is not surprising since the novel is set in Nigeria from the period of the 'genocide' of the Christians from the east- the Igbos, in the northern part of Nigeria to the subsequent secession that led to the inevitable civil war.

The themes here provide insight to the grave injustice and grave provocations the Igbos endured in the North in mid 1960s.

In sentence no. 22, <the Man's right eye> was gone; in its place, a juicy red pulp, reveals the harrowing experience of a man whose right eye was gorged out in the North and <flies> buzzed everywhere' all speak of decay. This is not just decay of filth or debris. These, from the themes above, show the decay and stench of blood emanating from human beings. It paints a gory image of the massacres the Igbo's endured at the hands of their Northern counterparts, the Jihadists. At a point the victims decide that '<secession>' is the only answer, having been subjected to inhumane treatments in Nigeria. The theme of religious war was also portrayed in the sentence '<it> was Allah's will'. The Northerners fighting a Jihad for Allah carried out a war on infidels.

2. Agent

The agent is the entity, that is, the initiator or doer of an action- the agent must be capable of volition or deliberate action.

Instances from the data above reveal the agents of the actions of the verb.

'<They> are killing us like ants

'<We> finished the whole family

Here we see agency, Abdulmalik and his cohorts bragging about how they deliberately murdered an entire family in the name of Allah and how the oppressed are crying out in despair, hence 'They' are killing us.

Also, we see <The soldiers>..., '<The security guards> folded their arms...'

Here, we see the Nigerian soldiers singling out the Igbos at the airport and shooting them in the chest. These barbaric and calculated attacks were executed by none other but the very soldiers who were supposed to protect all Nigerians, yet joining in the religious war; they shot the Igbos and left their dead bodies to decay on the roads. The ones who didn't join in the massacre simply stood by and watched as their comrades carried out genocide. Meanwhile, the actions of the victims were those of fear and trepidation E.g. '<Nnaemeka> Knelt down ...' '< Passengers> were crouched behind the chairs. We oppressor and the oppressed in the Nigerian society at the time. The unequal treatment meted out to Nigerians who are from the east.

3. Experiencer

The experiencer is the individual who feels or perceives the event. The experiencer is the entity which is aware of the action or state described by the predicate but is not in control of the action

or state.

In *Half of a Yellow Sun*, we see the experiencers, having no control of the violence around them because it was an ideology sanctioned by the Nigerian government through silence.

For instance

'<Richard> felt himself wet his trousers'

'<Ugwu> recoiled and nearly dropped the flask'

'<Olanna> saw the smoke rising tall . . . '

'<Richard> felt cold sweat weighting on his eye lashes'.

These roles depict the feelings of despair, horror and helplessness surrounding the people who experienced man's inhumanity to man in the 1960 pogrom.

We see Richard, Kainene's lover, a white man in Nigeria at the time 'wetting' his trousers at the sight of a Nigerian soldier shooting a young Igbo youth called 'Nnaemeka' because he couldn't say 'Allahu Akbar!'. Also Olanna while making her escape from the North saw buildings that were set ablaze by the riots. The buildings and businesses owned by the Igbos were set ablaze by the Northern Jihadists.

Meanwhile Ugwu who was in Enugu went to the train station to look for Olanna and to give tea and bread to those in need at the station. He witnessed the distasteful experiences of the Igbos who had managed to escape from the North. Some of them were in bad shape. They were injured, some lost their limbs and were limping and in the case of the man he offered bread, one of his eyes was gorged out. Hence his reaction, '<Ugwu> recoiled and nearly dropped the flask. The harrowing situation was too much for Ugwu to withstand so he dropped the bread with the man and ran out of the train station, he did not stop until he got home.

4. Location

This is the place (concrete or abstract) where something is situated. It is the place where an action takes place.

With the meaning derived from the arguments in the novel, readers are able to understand better where the actions and situations in novel took place.

In the instances below:

'<In Sabon Gari>, the first street was empty' The location of Sabon Garri is in the North where the genocide of the Igbo had begun, the street is deserted because most of the people who did business there were Igbos, most of whom would have been killed and some other escaped for their lives. Also '<the railway stations> are full'. This speaks of the location where the escaping Igbos gathered en mass to escape to the east by train since all the roads were blocked by the Jihadists who searched every moving vehicle for runaway Igbos to murder.

Also 'He said hundreds were killed <in Zaria alone> the location of the action of the verb 'kill' being Zaria, also helps the readers know that the actions that led to the civil war in Nigeria started from the North with the wanton killings of the Igbos, a provocation, that neither pride nor cowardice would suffer them to ignore. Thus the Igbos were made to crouch <behind the chairs>

just to hide from the Nigerian soldiers who instead protecting all Nigerians had instead pledged allegiance to Jihad.

5. Goal

This is the entity towards which something moves literally. The entity towards which a motion takes place. The motion may be concrete or abstract.

In the novel as inferred from the sentences presented in the data above, the goal of the pogrom was to wipe out the entire Igbos resident in the North. They were called infidels, in other words, 'unbelievers', 'It was <Allah's will>

Hence the goal of the Jihad, a religious war, fought on behalf of Allah by Muslims in the North, was the extermination of infidels (*iyamiri*).

Having pushed the Igbos to the wall they begin to clamour for their own country where their bitter experiences would not be repeated again. Thus we see another goal: '<Biafra> is born

The declaration of secession from the Nigerian government by Colonel Chukwuemeka Odimegwu Ojukwu was thus another catalyst that led the country to a 36 months' civil war. Thus, the realization of Biafra was short lived as another period of pogrom went on during the civil war, many of the Igbo extraction died as they were only wounded lions who were not prepared for the war. The war eventually ended in a 'no victor no vanquished'.

Conclusion

The critical linguistic study of theta roles in Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Half of a Yellow Sun* offer a solid description of how theta roles function as meaning encoders in the overall syntactic constructions in the text. The arguments in the novel under study have proven that meaning is embedded in the language of literary discourse therefore more attention should be paid to the syntactic configurations of the language of literature. Also, this paper has tried to prove that theta roles should not only function to restrict the ill-formedness of sentences within the X¹ theory but should be employed in the analysis of verbs and their arguments in literary works since by examining the entities that perform, receive, experience or give more information about these roles in literary works, a more meaningful projection is achieved.

It is therefore recommended that more studies on theta roles in literary works should be carried out.

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